Farmers and sellers of perishable products such as vegetables, fish and milk products were forced to watch their life's savings waste away before their eyes.

Small businesses across the country went bankrupt and had to shut down, even though they had full order books, employees at work and money in the bank. They went bankrupt, not because they were incompetent business people, but simply because they were deprived of their own money and had no liquidity to pay their employees and their suppliers.

Stories of the elderly and sick who were stranded without cash, students who found themselves unable to pay fees, and the millions of Indians who suffered in myriad ways under the note ban have not been included for want of space. But their stories do matter and the distress and inconvenience they suffered were very real.

The architects of demonetization had thoughtlessly sucked the liquidity out of a well-functioning economy and left an entire nation, and especially the poorest of poor, gasping for breath.

In terms of the human toll it extracted, India's 2016 demonetization sadly turned out to be a catastrophe.